of the high command, engaged the same poll strategists the party used in Karnataka. Their task is a herculean one. Rajasthan is notorious for voting out incumbents: the past four elections have followed the script. The positives are that the BJP campaign has so far looked rudderless, with even the big state leaders looking to the high command for direction. Keeping Raje out of the loop has also not worked, although it seems the drubbing in Karnataka has forced a rethink on this. Raje, the strongest BJP leader in the state, is forging a strategy of her own. As news channels chased Pilot on Sunday, she was attending a Ram *katha* in Rishikesh, Uttarakhand, where she took a dig at the two Congress leaders, asking them to "learn from the Ramayana" how not to hanker for the throne.

The other state BJP leaders have been busy attending rallies thrown by their caste brethren, indicating that the party is testing what kind of sway they have. Raje is one of the few leaders who avoid embracing any caste publicly—that she has kin among the Rajputs, Jats and Gujjars helps this crossover appeal. The BJP central command—that is, the think-tank of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and home minister Amit Shah—obviously has some ED-plus strategy to make things difficult for the Congress, but if they do not get Raje aboard as the CM face, they risk battling Gehlot-Pilot entirely on the Modi charisma plank with no buffer in case of a defeat.

The BJP hopes the graft charges will damage Gehlot, who has hitherto enjoyed a relatively clean image. But it will be mindful of the fact that a perceived witch-hunt could create sympathy for the CM. Especially since there's no BJP wave as such and it hopes to ride on anti-incumbency alone, the margin of error may be narrow. In 2020, when the Pilot revolt was on, the ED and I-T department had carried out raids on some of Gehlot's aides and his estranged brother. That report was never made public. Will it become a factor now? ■



SLOW BURN
BJP's national secretary Pankaja Munde

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PAIN POINTS

By Dhaval Kulkarni

It was a scathing statement that Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) national secretary and former Maharashtra minister Pankaja Munde made earlier this month—one that could only have been a sign of festering wounds growing bigger. On May 31, at a public meeting organised in Delhi by the Rashtriya Samaj Paksha (RSP), an ally of the BJP, Pankaja, the daughter of the late OBC stalwart and BJP leader Gopinath Munde, boldly declared, "I belong to the BJP, but the BJP does not belong to me." On that same day, her sister and BJP's Beed MP Pritam Munde broke ranks and came out in support of the wrestlers protesting against the Wrestling Federation of India chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh. Another statement bristling with intent, if not exactly dissent, followed barely days later. At an event to mark her father's death anniversary on June 3, Pankaja said she'll take up her grievances with Union home minister Amit Shah. "My leader is Amit Shah. I'll meet him and have a free-wheeling discussion," she said.

Old grudges die hard. Fault lines between the BJP and the Munde sisters, who belong to the Vanjari community, have been growing since Pankaja's shock defeat in the 2019 assembly polls to estranged cousin and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader Dhananjay